

6 key types of qualitative research:

- Phenomenology
- Grounded theory
- Ethnography
- Case studies
- Participatory action research

Criteria for assessing qualitative studies:

- Credibility: results and conclusions make sense from perspective of research participants
- Transferability: sufficient information provided about context/participants/assumptions underlying the research so reader can assess potential transferability of findings to other, similar settings
- Dependability: detail is provided about each step in research process and contextual factors that influenced decisions about research process
- Confirmability: a critical examination of the 'chain of evidence' indicates that the researcher's conclusions are supported by the data

Trustworthiness: A Qualitative Concern

- Researchers should report on methods employed to ensure quality of findings
- Triangulation: multiple sources of data, data collection strategies, researcher perspectives, theories
- Member checking: participants verified interpretations of data

Qualitative Data Collection:

- Qualitative research contributes to in-depth understanding of a topic
- Researcher is primary data collection/analysis instrument
- Best way to engage low-literacy populations
- Allows people to tell their own stories in their own words

Purposive Sampling/Quota Sampling:

- Target number is set for participants based on a characteristic to ensure group reflects diversity of group
- Select 'critical cases': individuals that are the most/least likely to have healthy knowledge/attitudes/practices
- Select 'typical cases': individuals that represent the majority in terms of health knowledge/attitudes/practices

Convenience Sampling:

- Accept anyone who fits your criteria
- Sample selected from whoever happens to be available at a given time/place

- Any individuals who respond to recruitment advertisements
- Individuals who are already fathered in a social/work/educational setting
- 'Snowball sampling' technique: people being interviewed recommend acquaintances for subsequent interviews

Ethical Considerations:

- Ensure all participants give informed consent
- Don't pressure participants to answer questions if they aren't comfortable
- Focus groups: need to clarify that participants' contributions will be shared with the group. Encourage participants to keep confidential information spread in meeting
- Researchers should keep interview and focus group data anonymous

Informed Consent:

- Brief description of the purpose and procedure of research, including expected duration
- Statement of any risks, discomforts, inconveniences associated with participation
- Guarantee of anonymity and confidentiality
- Identification, affiliation, sponsorship of research as well as contact information
- Statement that participant is completely voluntary and can be terminated at any time without penalty
- A statement of any benefits to participants involved
- Offer to receive summary of findings

Data Management:

- Recording responses verbatim (recording device or write down word-for-word answers of respondents) is general rule for qualitative data collection
- Always back up audio recordings with written notes
- Remove identifying info
- Store recordings/notes/transcripts securely

Transcribing:

- Converting rough notes/audio recordings into word-processed computer files
- Transcribe recordings ASAP after interview
- Provide transcriber with a glossary/acronym list if they're unfamiliar with vocab
- 2-3 hrs to transcribe one hour of interview recording, 5-6 hours to transcribe one hour of focus group recording

Interviews vs Focus Groups: Which to Use:

1. Interviews: easier to control interaction with an individual vs a group, can avoid major scheduling hassles with only 1 person. More detailed with follow up questions,

and probing for meaning, and more private as people may not feel comfortable discussing some topics in group setting

2. Focus groups: efficient for collection of large amount of data quickly, can allow for a common consensus among group of community members and may allow for a better understanding of the social context (interactions with others)

Types of info from interview and focus groups:

- experience/behavior
- Feelings
- opinions/values
- Background context
- Sensory
- knowledge

Interviews:

Unstructured interviewing aka intensive/in-depth interviewing:

- interview focuses on respondent's subjective experiences: ask them to 'tell their story'
- Respondents describe in detail and in their own words the situation as it is meaningful to them
- Interviewer asks 1 or 2 broad questions, encouraging respondents to share perspective without interruption. Interviewer free to probe, ask follow up questions
- Shared meanings cannot be assumed- important to ask for clarification, attempt to arrive at some understanding between interviewer and respondents

Semi-structured Interviewing:

- Used when researcher knows something about the area of interest but not enough to know all the answers
- Researcher prepares open-ended questions in advance, may also prepare probing or follow-up questions
- Interview guide: a set of open-ended questions asked in a specific order
- Number of questions asked should be minimised to avoid interrupting the flow of the interview

Structured Interviewing:

- Assumes that:
 - There is a common vocabulary for all potential respondents
 - Responses can be precoded categories
 - The context of each questions is obvious
- All interviewers are trained to conduct each interview in exactly the same way

- Interviewers read a script explaining purpose of study and to cover respondents rights
- Interviewers ask all change with no change in wording/order of presentations
- If probes are allowed, they are usually scripted prior to interview

Interview Guide:

- Interview guide specifies the topics on which info is sought
- Guide shouldn't be restrictive, just keep conversation on track as respondent has control over how they relate their experiences
- Questions are worded in order to elicit in-depth answers
- Questions should be clear and neutral (not leading)
- Questions should be ordered logically, cover one topic/issue each
- Interviewer should allow person to bring up topics not on questions, be prepared to follow their train of thought

Consideration for Interviews:

- Location
- Arranged in advance, confirmed
- Time of day
- Safety/privacy
- Translation
- Recorder app
- Horarium

Interviewer Training:

- Interviews are trained in:
 - Good interpersonal relations
 - Listening skills
 - Good interviewing techniques
- Interviewers should emphasize importance of study, value of respondents' participation
- Interview should allow for exploration while ensuring initial questions get answers
- Interviewers should have strong understanding of research topic and of perspective of respondents regarding said topic

Conducting Interviews:

- Build rapport
- Explain situation
- Obtain informed consent
- Get permission to record interview
- Use probes for detail/elaboration/clarification
- Be flexible and responsive to participants

- Exit interview diplomatically

Interviewer as the Research Participants::

- Important to minimise interviewer influence on respondent
- Interviewer may have to clarify purpose of question/give instructions about how to answer questions
- Self-disclosure should be avoided if it is leading to interviewer bias
- Interviewees should dress appropriately for respondent being interviewed

Focus Groups:

- a group interview in which a group of individuals are selected and assembled by researchers to discuss and comment on, from personal experience, the research topic

The Role of Interaction:

- Interaction between participants produces insight and data about (their view of the world, the language they use about an issue, their values and beliefs about an issue)
- Interaction also enables participants to ask questions of each other, as well as to elaborate and consider their own details of their specific experiences

Benefits of Focus Group:

- Enables researcher to gain large amount of info quickly
- Acknowledges power differences between participants and researchers
- Captures everyday language and culture
- Can explore degree of consensus on a given topic
- Elicit multiplicity of view, emotional response, explanation of behaviors and attitudes
- Insight into people shared understanding of everyday life, ways in which individuals are influenced by others in a group situation

Benefits for Participants:

- Involved in decision making processes
- Valued as experts
- Given chance to work collaboratively with researcher
- Trust develops and the group explores solutions to a particular problem as a unit rather than as individuals
- Actively involved in something which they feel will make a difference

Limitations of Focus Groups:

- Cannot generalize findings to a whole pop
- Research has less control over the data produced
- Participants are not necessarily expressing their own definitive individual view

- Certain people may not feel comfortable participating in a group setting
- Participants may not feel that they can trust others with sensitive/personal information
- Focus groups cannot promise complete confidentiality/anonymity

Focus Groups are Inappropriate When:

- You're testing hypotheses/when you need statistical data
- Your group is too large/your topic is too big for a focused discussion
- Your primary aim is to save time and money
- Your topic is not something participants are knowledgeable about
- You bring together participants who are uncomfortable with each other
- Your topic will create unacceptable levels of stress in participants

Practical Organization of Focus Groups:

- Recommended number of people per group is 6-10
- Sessions usually last 1-2 hours
- Pick neutral, convenient location
- Group composition:
 - Participants shouldn't be too different as some may feel uncomfortable sharing
 - Participants shouldn't be too similar because diverse opinions and experiences may not be revealed
- Recommended to have one moderator and one person to take notes/monitor recording equipment

Role of the Moderator:

- 4 key techniques: listening, paraphrasing, probing, note-taking
- Moderator responsible for:
 - Promoting debate by asking open-ended questions
 - Challenge participants to draw diverse range of responses
 - Probe for details, move things forward
 - Keep session focused and on course
 - Keep participants speaking one at a time
 - Ensure everyone speaks and participates
 - Not show too much approve, don't favour participants
 - Avoid giving personal details, don't influence participants towards a particular position/opinion

How many focus groups?

- Population is 'segmented' according to various factors of research interest
- Reflect all existing segments in the youth pop

- Avoid inadequate sampling, overkill, and inappropriate mixing
- Rule: if budget/time allow, conduct at least 2 focus groups per segment to provide a greater range of views and greater confidence in results

Setting up focus groups:

- Convenient day/time/location
- Pay attention to physical comfort of room, refreshments, etc
- Contact participants day before to confirm time/location
- Over-recruit (invite 2-3 extra participants)
- Make/aid/pay for travel arrangements if necessary

Conducting Focus Groups:

1. Offer refreshments, allow participants to start group formation
2. Moderator explains research project, obtains informed consent from participants
3. Ask participants to introduce themselves
4. Ground rules for discussion (behaviour)
5. Say how many questions will be covered
6. Moderator asked question using focus group guide
7. Observer monitors audio recording, takes notes during discussion
8. Opportunity for participants to ask questions

The Focus Group Guide:

- Prepare outline of discussion topics to direct sessions
- Degree of structure in questions depends on how much is knowledge on area of investigation
- Moderators technique and focus group guide should be tested prior
- Mention that you need as many diverse thoughts as possible
- Too many questions usually leads to less information about research themes